Project Heavyweight — Vision & Movement Design

Oct 24, 2026 · @Mark Burney · *Working title — rename at will*

Vision

Your weight is the key: a heavy hero who solves a fragile world by moving through it deliberately.

The pitch: *Wario Land in 3D* — a 3D puzzle-platformer where mass and momentum are the player's entire toolkit. The hero is big, heavy, and proud of it. The world is structural and fragile: it bears weight, breaks under it, pivots around it, and permanently reshapes as the player applies force with intent. Movement itself is the puzzle language — how fast you arrive, from how high, and whether the ground can take it.

The logline: a bull in a china shop — where the bull learns exactly what to break. The idiom means careless destruction; the game subverts it. Players start as the idiom (crashing into everything, cheap and funny) and become its contradiction (a deliberate, precise force). Always pitch both clauses together — the first half alone sounds like a pure action game, which this is not.

The movement identity in one line: **precise when slow, unstoppable when committed — and the transition between the two is the skill.**

Genre position: a *deliberate* game, not an action game. Spectacle (collapses, smashed walls, toppled giants) is the payoff for thinking, never the loop itself. Tone stays joyful and warm — deliberate does not mean dour.

Scope commitment: **strictly single-player.** No multiplayer mode is planned or designed for — the core systems (persistent personal world-sculpting, authored puzzle states, a told-tale framing) assume one player and one save.

Design pillars

Every future idea is tested against these four. A feature that serves none of them is cut, no matter how cool.

1. **Committed movement.** Inputs respond instantly; the body takes time. Speed is earned, hard to steer, and expensive to stop. Mastery means planning motion, not reacting.
2. **Weight is a reasoning tool.** Mass, thresholds, pivots, and impact force are a consistent system the player thinks with — not a combat stat and not a gimmick.
3. **Destruction is legible and consequential.** The player can read what will break before committing. Breaking the wrong thing is a real mistake — and every mistake is recoverable.
4. **Joyful, not dour.** A warm, funny, confident game. The hero's bulk is competence and charm. Deliberate pacing never means grim tone.

Tiebreak rule: when two ideas conflict, the *deliberate/puzzle* reading wins over the *action/spectacle* reading. Spectacle is the reward for deliberate play.

The hero

A large, heavy-set, big-hearted protagonist whose mass is their superpower. Design intent, stated so art and writing never drift from it: **the hero's weight is strength, skill, and charm — never the punchline.** The character is confident in their body; the world's fragility is the world's problem.

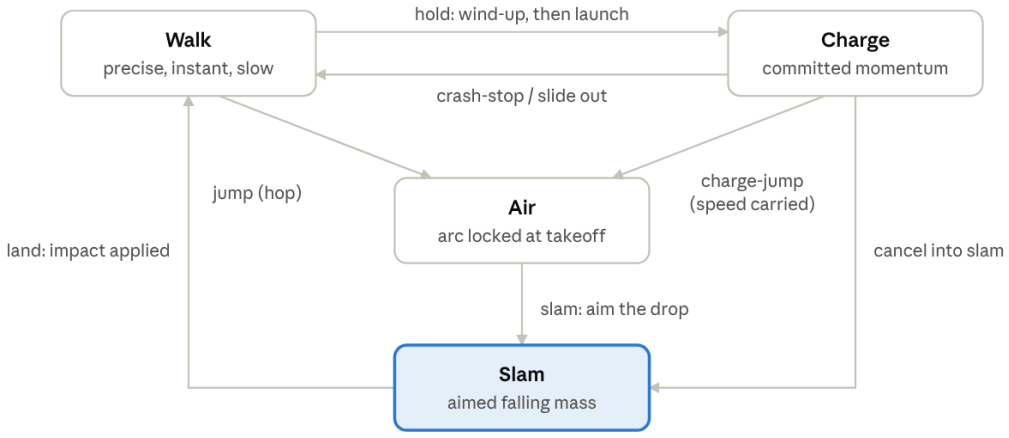
Personality lives in the animation: instant, eager responses to input (head turns, feet plant, body leans the moment the stick moves) with mass expressed through follow-through — long slides, heavy landings, ground that reacts. The character should read as *powerful and happy about it*, in the Wario tradition of an unflinching body played for warmth.

Movement system

Movement is modal, not continuous: the hero has a precise mode and a committed mode, and switching between them deliberately is the core skill. This is the Wario Land architecture — walking Wario is unremarkable on purpose; ramming Wario is the game. One continuous system cannot serve both puzzle precision and momentum joy; a state machine serves both without compromise.

Cardinal rule — instant inputs, heavy body. Every input gets a same-frame response (animation starts, intent registers). The *mass* is what takes time: acceleration curves, braking slides, wide turn arcs, committed jump trajectories. Players read input latency as bad controls and momentum curves as weight. Never confuse the two; never add delay to feel heavy.

Precise when slow, unstoppable when committed



movement state machine · 4 states, 7 transitions

Every arrow is a player decision except the landing; soft landings from Air return to Walk the same way. The Slam box is the accent because it is the signature verb and the bridge between modes.

Steering authority: speed is purchased with control

Steering authority is a **continuous falling function of speed** — one curve, not a hard mode toggle. The movement identity in full: **the controls never stop working — they change meaning with speed.** There is no regime where the player is a passenger; each regime has its own grammar:

- **Slow — the stick commands.** Below the walk-speed threshold, control is exact and instant, non-negotiable. This anchor is what keeps puzzle execution blameless: a player stuck on a puzzle must never be able to blame the controls.
- **Fast — the stick influences, the boost steers.** At momentum speeds the stick is a nudge on a mass in flight. The real steering is the **boost**: a discrete impulse that redirects by *adding* momentum in the input direction — vector addition, never a velocity rewrite. Course correction makes you faster and more committed; that is the point. A cooldown or limited taps keeps boosting from being pulsed into full authority.
- **Stopping — the slam-brake.** Slamming from motion kills horizontal momentum by delivering it into the ground. Impact force scales with the speed being killed, so braking hard on fragile footing breaks it — rule 2 applied to yourself. The emergency brake is never free, always available, and doubles as a deliberate tool: brake on purpose to punch through a floor.

Two guardrails on this system:

- Low-speed engagement comes from the **world** — thresholds, slopes, fragile spans — never from loosened controls. Walk mode stays exact; the terrain supplies the tension.
- Crashing is the explicit learning curve, so **early crashes are cheap and funny**: bounce, dust cloud, get up. Stakes rise with world fragility across the game, never with the controls getting looser.

The verb set

Verb	State	What it does	How it expresses weight
Walk / Run	Walk	Slow, exact positioning: aiming, plates, pivots, ledges	Tight and responsive; deliberately unglamorous. The manipulation mode
Charge (roll/ram)	Charge	Wind-up, then committed high-speed travel. The traversal verb	Telegraphed launch, degraded steering, no free brakes, real impact force
Jump	Walk or Charge	Arc locked at takeoff; minimal air steering	Distance scales with ground speed — a charge-jump is a cannonball, a standing jump is a hop
Slam	Any airborne state	Aimed downward impact. Attack, breaker, pressure input, see-saw launcher — and the brake: kills horizontal	Force scales with drop height and carried speed — braking hard can break your own footing. The

Verb	State	What it does	How it expresses weight
		momentum by delivering it into the ground	signature verb
Crash-stop / slide	Charge exit	Ending a charge: hit something, slide out, or cancel into slam	Stopping is itself a mechanic with a cost
Boost	Charge or Air	Discrete impulse in the stick direction — the steering vocabulary at speed; course-corrects a committed trajectory	Redirects by adding momentum, never rewriting it — correcting makes you faster and more committed; limited by a cooldown

Build priority: **the slam is this game's A-press** — the most-used, most-satisfying verb and the bridge between modes (charge → slam converts horizontal speed into aimed impact). The controller is tuned around the fall feeling incredible before anything else.

The four charge properties

The charge is a decision with a blast radius, not movement automation. It preserves the weight fantasy only if all four hold:

1. **A wind-up, not a cast.** A visible ~0.5 s plant-and-rear before launch. The time cost of mass is paid as a telegraphed decision, not smeared across sluggish throttle.
2. **Degraded steering.** Wide arcs or near-locked heading while charging. Aiming *before* committing is the skill; early loss of control is the mastery curve, not friction.
3. **No free brakes.** A charge ends by impact (payoff or bounce-stun), by long slide (sliding past the ledge is on you), or by canceling into the slam — the escape hatch is itself a weight expression and a puzzle input.
4. **The speed is real.** Charge velocity obeys the same conservation as everything else: slopes add or bleed it, impacts transfer it, jumps inherit it, struck objects and enemies receive it. The moment the charge becomes a scripted animation with special-cased speed, the system is betrayed.

Net effect: top speed is *higher* than an agile hero's, but it must be earned, aimed, and survived. The hero is only "slow" for the first two seconds of any plan.

Momentum as earned resource

- Slow from a standstill; devastating once rolling. Weight gates speed, it never caps it.
- Downhill slopes are free acceleration — converting height into speed is the game's currency, in both directions (slam converts speed/height back into force).
- Jump distance scaling makes run-up planning a constant micro-decision.

Tuning parameters (expose all of these in the inspector)

Walk speed · charge wind-up duration · charge acceleration curve · charge top speed · turn radius vs. speed curve · slide friction · jump speed-scaling factor · air-steer authority · slam drop acceleration · impact force scalar · crash-stun / recovery duration · slope accel/decel multipliers · steering-authority curve (control vs. speed) · boost impulse strength · boost cooldown / tap count · brake impact scalar. The design lives in these curves; expect most of prototype week to be spent here.

Engine note (Godot): kinematic `CharacterBody3D` with hand-authored curves — fake the mass, never rigid-body-drive the hero. True simulated heavy controllers are notoriously miserable to make feel good; authored curves read as weight and play as a learnable system.

Weight is 50% feedback. Thud, screenshake, dust, crack decals, rumble, landing FOV kick, camera lag behind acceleration. Sluggish and weighty are the same numbers with different presentation — so placeholder juice goes in *during greybox*. For this game it is not polish; it is the mechanic.

Universal weight rules

The BOTW lesson: don't bulletproof individual puzzles — ship a small set of globally consistent rules, state problems clearly, and let any rule-combination that works count as a win. These six rules apply everywhere, with **zero per-room exceptions**:

1. **Surfaces have visible weight thresholds.** Material and visual state (cracks, sag, creak) telegraph what a surface can bear before anyone steps on it.
2. **Momentum transfers on impact.** Speed × mass delivered into whatever is struck — walls, enemies, objects, pivots.
3. **The heavier side of a pivot wins.** See-saws, counterweights, hinged structures resolve by mass, always.
4. **Falling mass scales with height.** A slam from higher hits harder; drop height is a resource the player positions for.
5. **Enemies obey the same physics as the player.** Their weight breaks floors, tips pivots, and transfers momentum — which is what makes them puzzle material.
6. **Broken stays broken** (world scale). Destruction persists and only ever adds traversal options; discrete puzzle contraptions get local resets.

Engineering consequence: these rules must behave identically everywhere, so they are built as **one physics/interaction layer early** — never as per-level scripts. Systems amortize across the whole game; scripted content doesn't. This front-loads engineering and is the right trade for a small team.

Destruction & puzzle design

Destruction is a **move**, not an outburst. In this blend, breaking the wrong thing is allowed to be a mistake — that's where tension and mastery live — under one non-negotiable rule:

Every destruction consequence is previewable; every puzzle state is recoverable. Players can read what will break before committing (thresholds, rule 1), and a botched setup always has a reset: respawning contraption pieces, room-reset levers, rebuild-on-reentry for discrete puzzles. At world scale, recoverability is structural instead: breaks only ever add options (rule 6), so no reachable

sequence of destruction can strand the player. Irreversible mistakes with no reset produce rage-quits, not "aha."

Unintended solutions stance: celebrate, with guardrails. Rooms are stated as *problems*, not locks — any application of the weight rules that reaches the goal counts. Guardrails:

- **Goals are always legible**, even when solutions are open. Players forgive being stumped; they don't forgive being lost.
- **Cheese must cost effort or cleverness.** If "slam everything until it breaks" dominates, the fix is threshold tuning, never scripting.
- **Playtest for the degenerate solution, not the intended one.** Whatever lazy players find optimal is what the game *really is* — watch for it and tune it.

Technical rule: **author the physics, simulate the garnish.** Pre-fractured meshes with designed break points, topples along intended arcs with simulated wobble, thresholds as tuned numbers rather than true force integration. It reads as physics; it plays as a learnable system.

Transformations — the food-attack system

Wario Land-style reaction transformations, resolved into one world rule: **still food is food; moving food is ammunition.** Transformation foods never sit in the world as pickups — they only arrive as *attacks*: thrown, dropped, launched, rolled, or chasing. Auto-eat is simply the hit reaction (Miri reflexively catches it in her mouth), and **standing into a telegraphed food-attack on purpose is the transformation input.** Dodge it: nothing happens. Accept it: you chose the tool. Player agency is preserved in both directions, with zero new controls.

The fiction: the pirates stole the harvest, so **their ammunition is the village's food** — they are perpetually arming the one creature who eats everything, and Miri eating incoming ordnance depletes their supply.

Delivery taxonomy (mapped to the draft crew):

- **Lobbed** — storks drop chili bombs and beehives from above
- **Launched** — tortoise-built food catapults and cannons: fixed emplacements that double as on-demand, renewable transformation dispensers beside the puzzles that need them (and are potentially re-aimable by Miri to deliver forms elsewhere)
- **Chasers** — feral produce animated by mishandled seed-magic; pursuing food marks pirate-held territory and doubles as a world-state readout
- **Rolling mass** — boulder-scale produce: hazard, transformation source, and weight object in one

Standing rules:

1. Every food-attack obeys the cartoon-telegraphy rule (readable at decision distance, staged like a gag) and the universal weight rules — a thrown melon is a mass with momentum like everything else.
2. **Forms end fast and diegetically** — water douses the fireball, a slam or sunlight shatters the ice, thorns pop the blimp — with a short timer as backstop. A mistaken transformation is a thirty-

second joke, never a punishment; cure sources are placed as deliberately as attack sources, and that pairing *is* the puzzle vocabulary.

3. **Form cap: three or four.** Every form must pass the weight-grammar test — it alters mass, friction, or control authority, or it's cut:

Form	Weight-grammar statement	Puzzle role
Fireball	Destruction by other means	Burns rope, thatch, and timber that mass can't crack — a second material language
Ice block	Friction zero, authority zero	The authority curve at absolute bottom: pure committed momentum, aim before you freeze
Blimp	Mass zero	The inversion gag: reach heights, but thresholds and pivots stop answering to you
Honey (candidate)	Friction maxed	The anti-ice; stork-dropped hives

Enemies: fewer, larger, structural

A small pool of huge, weighty enemies — and they are **mobile puzzle elements first, combat targets second**. Because enemies obey the same physics as the player (rule 5), each one is a reusable puzzle noun:

- A felled giant is a **bridge** or a ramp.
- A lured heavy enemy is a **counterweight**, a **pressure-plate holder**, or a **wall-breaker** you aim.
- "The bigger they are, the harder they fall" is literal structural physics: toppling an enemy *onto* something is a solution verb.
- An enemy's own weight is a hazard the level exploits — floors that hold the player but not the giant chasing them.

This philosophy also fits the content budget: each enemy is a system that recombines across many rooms, not an encounter to balance. Design each one as a *moving mass with a behavior*, then ask what rooms can do with that mass.

No-death & bosses

There is no death. Damage produces comedic reactions, never a life lost — consistent with cartoon logic, the fable register, and "early crashes are cheap and funny." The penalty design law that replaces it: **every penalty is live and in-arena — never travel time.**

- **Field damage:** reaction + knockback + the player's collected food *scatters* (recoverable scramble, Sonic-ring model). Enemies grab scattered food and flee — theft becomes **a chase you can win** (the pelican stuffing his pouch until the payload rule grounds him), converting punishment into gameplay.
- **Boss doctrine, in the lead's words:** *"The boss fight isn't who survives, but who gets away with the reward — nobody dies."* Bosses are folklore contests with physics: each is a multi-phase

structural puzzle where the player spends a phase setting up a collapse (lure, break supports, load the counterweight). Getting hit never hurts Miri — it **regresses the setup**: weaver-bird riggers swoop in and repair what she broke while she recovers. Tension = defending work-in-progress, which is the correct tension for a puzzle game.

- **Bounds:** a hit undoes the current step, never the whole fight (full resets in a no-death game feel like death with extra steps). **Ejection from the arena is banned** — every reset is instant and in-place.
- Optional flavor: a boss opens by stealing something specific (a seed, the boost) so the fight is a retrieval with personal stakes.

World design

Structure: **Mario 64 / Banjo-Kazooie playground worlds** — open, explorable, objectives scattered — with one adaptation: in those games the world is a stage for movement; here **the world itself is the puzzle**. The macro-structure is literally load-bearing: towers that fall particular ways, strata that crack open, see-saw geography, structures whose destruction order determines what's reachable. Each objective is a structural problem, not an obstacle course. Linear sequences are used only where a specific puzzle demands them.

Persistent destruction is the progression system. Worlds are re-entered repeatedly, and broken stays broken — every solved problem permanently reshapes the world: carved shortcuts, felled bridges, opened caverns. A late-game save file's world looks sculpted by that player's history. Design discipline this requires: author worlds so that no reachable sequence of breaks strands the player — at macro scale, destruction only ever adds traversal options. (This also delivers the havoc payoff: watching the world permanently deform under you, earned through deliberate play.)

The terrain must talk back. Deliberate movement stays engaging only when the ground constantly demands micro-decisions — thresholds, slopes, pivots, fragile spans everywhere. A heavy hero on flat empty ground is boring by definition; density of weight-reactive terrain is the level-design KPI.

Scope: fewer, denser worlds. Target **3–4 playground worlds** absolutely packed with structural interaction — on the order of 40–60 strong puzzle setups total — rather than many sparse ones. Handcrafted puzzle content is slow; the fewer-but-larger philosophy applies to the level count too.

Mission structure — worlds as operations

Each world is a **pirate operation to dismantle** (the Sly Cooper spine): the hare scouts it; a mandatory mission chain sabotages it stage by stage; and **each story mission authors a major permanent destruction event** — collapse their crane, sink the loading dock, drop the cliffside onto the tunnels. Story progress is *legible as rubble*: the persistent-destruction system and the narrative structure are the same system. Around the spine, the playground stays fully open (seeds, food routes, transformation puzzles, side quests seeded by rescued captives). **No ejection, ever** — collect and keep playing. The village is the recovering hub. Open: what gates world-to-world progression (story missions, seed counts, or both) — the only law is diegetic justification.

Post-game: revival is the reward

Collected-out worlds feel dead because collectibles are *subtractive* — every pickup taken removes a reason to exist. This game inverts the arc: each world's lifecycle is **occupied → liberated → rehabilitated**. After liberation, worlds repopulate — captives come home, markets reopen, wildlife returns, kids play in the rubble you made — and **replanted seeds visibly grow**: crops, groves, and canopy bloom across the world, leaving it *fuller* than it ever was mid-campaign. The living, restored, bustling world is itself the endgame reward — seeing it is the point. Seasoning stays light and optional — the hare's traversal races through the reshaped terrain, renewable harvest runs, a few mini-games — never a post-game chore list. Scope honesty: restoration states are mostly art dressing plus NPC placement on the persistence state machine the game already requires.

Creative direction — DRAFT, return to this

> ***Status: provisional.*** *This section records the creative brainstorm so far. Items marked* ***agreed*** *have team/lead sign-off in principle; everything else is a working draft to be challenged, fleshed out, and ratified before art or writing production starts. Characters and story in particular need a dedicated pass.*

Setting — agreed

A fantastical world inspired by the **Swahili coast and Eastern/Southern Africa** — dhow-age maritime culture, coast-to-highland geography (baobabs, termite-mound towers, kopje boulder stacks, rift escarpments, rope-and-timber architecture: structural, breakable terrain). Narrative register is the region's **animal-fable tradition** — trickster tales, clever-vs-strong morality stories — which structurally matches the game's "outsmart the bigger mass" design. The society is **mixed-species** (one village, many animals), which keeps conflicts about choices rather than kinds.

Inspired-by rule (standing): anchor in the region but build invented places, spirits, and figures that *rhyme* with the source — never depict real peoples' sacred figures or practices. Spiritual elements tie to invented land-features (the Great Baobab), not borrowed deities. Budget research time; plan a cultural-consultant pass before commercial release. Keep the pirate aesthetic firmly in the folkloric fable register.

Miri, the hero — draft, return to

Young adult elephant girl; the village layabout. **Wrong for the job in spirit, the only right one in fact:** lazy, irreverent, food-obsessed — and physically the only creature on the coast who can do this. A **lazy genius whose full competence activates only when food is at stake**; every heroic feat gets reframed by her as food logistics.

- Inciting incident (draft): she slept through the pirate raid after the harvest feast; the able-bodied who gave chase were captured. She quests for the worst reason, loudly.
- The MacGuffin: the pirates stole the **magical seeds** — not the food, the *source* of all future food.
- Arc rule: she **never reforms the appetite**; the circle of it quietly widens from "me" to "us." Key beat: the captain offers her his version of her dream (eat like royalty, stop caring) and she refuses — her appetite eats *with* people, his takes *from* them. Ending: saves everyone, immediately devours half the victory feast.

- **Hard character law (standing, extends the Hero section):** the comedy comes from her *priorities*, never her *body*. Her size is competence and the win condition of every room; the world never shames it. Write this into the art brief before concepting.

The captain — agreed in concept

A **hippo pirate captain**, Miri's dark mirror: extractive appetite vs. her communal one. The heaviest creature in the game — unbeatable by force, defeated by *structure* (draft finale: his own hoard-laden deck collapsed under him). Regional folklore of the hippo's appetite supports the casting.

The hare — draft, return to

The village's **actual celebrated champion** — fast, clever, adored, the one this story "should" belong to (the regional trickster-hare tradition made literal). He pursued the pirates first and **lost to the tortoise first mate** — a deliberate inversion of the fable — which wounds his identity and explains his early mockery of Miri. Arc: contempt → grudging scout/intel partner → respect → the one who tells *her* tale. Thesis beat: *fast finds the problem; heavy solves it.* Open: captured (rescue objective) vs. humiliated-and-home (earlier party member); exact role depth. Flagged as needing more time.

The elder — draft

A **pangolin elder** who keeps the Great Baobab (the seeds' source): armored, ancient, deliberate — the living thesis of "heavy and careful wins." Natural tutorializer for the authority curve.

The pirate crew — draft roster, return to

Each character is a **weight behavior first** — a puzzle noun with a folklore source and a crew job. Two governing rules (standing, pending ratification with the team):

- **Flight rule: nothing is exempt from weight.** Every flier has a "ground it" answer — the universal one is *payload* (flight has a weight limit). A flier that can never be grounded is forbidden.
- **Water rule: Miri doesn't swim — she sinks.** Seafloor walking with her trunk as snorkel; underwater, weight logic inverts (buoyancy pulls up, floats are inverted platforms, currents replace slopes). Water is a second weight grammar, not a new movement system.

Animal	Crew role	Weight behavior	Note
Tortoise (first mate)	The brains; crew engineers	Unflippable until slammed, then dome/ramp/platform; their contraptions are mid-game puzzle spaces	The schemer who beat the hare
Moles	Sappers	Undermine floors and footings from below	Attack the player's own physics
Hyenas	The muscle	Reckless chargers — momentum with no authority curve; demolish their own structures when dodged	What the player was in hour one; folklore's greedy fool

Animal	Crew role	Weight behavior	Note
Marabou storks	Lookouts, bombers	Aimed dropped weights — her verb used against her; grounded via payload rule	
Weaver birds	Riggers	Rebuild what Miri breaks — tempo pressure on destruction inside pirate territory only	Never violates broken-stays-broken elsewhere
Pelican	Quartermaster	Pouch = variable cargo mass; full means grounded; stealing the loot back re-arms him	Payload rule embodied
Crocodile (lieutenant)	Water boss	Ambusher where she's slowest; death-roll torques structures	First cut candidate if scope bites — reduce to one set-piece

Scope note: not all seven are required. If cutting: keep hyenas (folklore-essential) and weaver birds + pelican (most mechanically novel) longest.

Collectibles & village revival — parked, revisit

Draft economy: **food is the universal pickup**, with one standing tension — **eat it now** (heal/fuel, immediate and personal) vs. **bank it at home** (the village recovers as it's fed: vendors, mini-games, returning NPCs, the hub visibly rebuilding — permanent and communal). The me-vs-us arc, mechanized; per the character law, *neither choice is ever shamed*, and a fed village ultimately feeds Miri better than hoarding would. Draft roster (cap at four, each diegetically wanted): **Seeds** (progression — restoring them is the quest) · **Food** (economy + health) · **Legendary ingredients/recipes** (the rare "treasure" layer; cooking mini-game) · **Pourquoi tale scrolls** (lore system). Standing rule: **no collectible-count wall without diegetic justification.** Village-system scope tiers to choose later: *cosmetic* (visual recovery — nearly free, hub states exist anyway) / *functional* (recovery unlocks vendors and mini-games) / *systemic* (Chao-Garden-depth management — flagged as a scope trap for a four-person team).

Lore system — draft, low priority

Collectible **pourquoi tales** in the regional tradition ("Why the Hippo Lives in the River"), told per world/boss — each secretly a gameplay hint about that creature's weight behavior. Natural assignment for the team's writer; possibly the hare's redemption vehicle (the storyteller learns to tell someone else's tale).

Visual & audio direction — agreed in principle

Tex Avery / Looney Tunes energy **fused with coastal East African aesthetics** — not a cartoon set in Africa: the cartoon language itself is sourced regionally, at every layer.

- **Art keystone: Tingatinga.** A cel-shaded 3D interpretation of Tanzanian Tingatinga painting — saturated color, bold outlines, flat surfaces, playful exaggerated animals, decorative pattern fills: a parallel indigenous cartoon tradition, inherently bright, instantly distinctive. Supporting

vocabulary: kanga/kitenge textile patterns (kanga cloths carry printed proverbs — a diegetic channel for hints and flavor), Makonde carving forms, Swahili coral-stone architecture, carved doors, and dhows.

- **Storytelling frame: hadithi.** The whole game framed as a told tale (the Swahili call-and-response opening; the elder — later perhaps the hare — as narrator). This makes the fourth wall *diegetic*: Miri mugs at the story's audience; narrator interjections replace tutorial text; the pourquoi scrolls become the game's native format.
- **Sound: a regional gag language.** Ngoma drums, mbira/kalimba, taarab strings, and call-response vocals as the stinger-and-impact vocabulary — a kalimba glissando is the slide whistle, a ngoma hit the timpani. The weight-feedback layer ("juice is the mechanic") carries culture instead of being culture-neutral.
- **Comedy register: trickster logic.** Gags resolve the way the region's fables do — small outwits strong, hubris falls to cleverness, schemers caught in their own schemes (the hyenas' charges; the captain felled by his own hoard).
- **Standing rules:** *exaggerate the presentation, never the rules* — squash, stretch, smear, and mug, but the mass numbers underneath stay honest (the animation lies; the simulation never does). *Cartoon acting is the telegraphy system* — failing surfaces sweat, creak, and wince: threshold readout, joke, and art direction in one. *Don Bluth darkness is a dial* — intensity through atmosphere, scale, and stakes, never cruelty to Miri or a broken fable register.
- **Performance (the real meaning of "pared down"): run on broad hardware.** The correct art direction is also the cheap one: flat/cel shading (no PBR), minimal lighting, low-poly models behind chunky silhouettes, stepped/smear animation (fewer frames reading as *more* cartoon), cartoon SFX as the cheapest juice. Godot's Compatibility renderer is available if maximum reach is wanted; set a low hardware floor early and test against it from the first greybox. The true performance budget is **physics and persistence** — fracture debris counts, body sleeping/merging, despawn policy, world-state serialization — so the art savings are spent there. Engineering line-item, not an afterthought.

Creative open questions

- ☐Miri's full characterization pass — voice, design brief, the character law applied
- ☐The hare: captured vs. humiliated; depth of his role
- ☐Naming register: fable role-names vs. Swahili-rooted personal names — pick one convention, never mix
- ☐Final crew list and scope cuts
- ☐Village cast beyond the elder; village structure and culture
- ☐Story outline beat-by-beat (divergence scene placement, finale staging)
- ☐Cultural research plan and consultant budget
- ☐Final transformation roster — three or four forms, each passing the weight-grammar test
- ☐World-gating decision: story missions, seed counts, or both (diegetic justification required)
- ☐Village revival scope tier: cosmetic / functional / systemic

Known traps & the standing rules that contain them

Trap	Standing rule

Trap	Standing rule
Irreversible destruction soft-locks progress	Previewable + recoverable; at world scale, breaks only add paths
Emergent physics is unpredictable → no mastery	Author the physics, simulate the garnish; kinematic hero, pre-fractured meshes, tuned thresholds
Heavy reads as sluggish → "bad controls"	Instant inputs, heavy body; juice ships with greybox, not polish
Slam-everything cheese dominates	Tune thresholds, never script exceptions; playtest the lazy path
Handcrafted puzzle content burns the budget	3–4 dense worlds; systemic rules + reusable enemy nouns amortize
Puzzle precision fights momentum fun	Modal movement: walk state for precision, charge state for traversal
Vision drifts back toward pure action	Pillar tiebreak: deliberate wins; spectacle is the reward, not the loop

These rules are standing: a proposal that violates one needs this document amended first, not an exception granted quietly.

Open questions

- ☐**Charge renewability.** Starting stance: wind-up is the only cost; tune its length until pulsing the charge for short distances feels dumb. Fallbacks if that fails: recovery delay after crash-stops, or charge only initiates from near-standstill.
- ☐**B-primary or C-primary** (momentum-mastery lean vs. puzzle-logic lean). Decided by the greybox playtest, not by discussion: watch what the team gravitates to.
- ☐**Team alignment check.** Each member independently writes their one signature trailer moment before reading this doc's vision; compare against it. This blend is the farthest from the group's original "cause havoc" language — confirm it was chosen, not deferred to.
- ☐**Hero identity** — name, species/design, art direction. Constraint from the Hero section: weight is competence and charm, never the joke.
- ☐**Working title.** "Project Heavyweight" is a placeholder.
- ☐**Unintended-solutions stance ratification.** Celebrate-with-guardrails is the recommendation written here; the team should explicitly agree or push back.
- ☐**Boost economy and input.** Impulse strength, cooldown or tap count, ground vs. air availability — tuned so boosting can't be pulsed into full authority. Also decide the input: its own button, or the charge input tapped while already at speed?
- ☐**Swimming & water physics — major design pass needed.** The game needs strong swimming mechanics and water-based physics; this is flagged as important and deliberately unresolved. It must be reconciled with the draft water rule in Creative Direction (sink-and-walk, trunk snorkel,

inverted weight grammar): decide whether Miri swims, sinks, or both — and how water carries the weight system. Dedicated session before any aquatic world is designed.

Milestone 1: the greybox that proves or kills this

Scrap the ported Mario 64 verb set — an agility moveset made heavier can only produce a worse Mario. Build the modal controller from scratch instead. Budget: roughly a weekend to a week, most of it spent in the tuning parameters.

Build list

- ☐Kinematic `CharacterBody3D` controller: walk state, charge state (all four properties), momentum-scaled jump, aimed slam, charge→slam cancel
- ☐All tuning parameters exposed in the inspector
- ☐Placeholder juice wired in from day one: landing thud SFX, screenshake, dust puff, ground-crack decal, FOV kick, camera lag
- ☐Test room with reactive props: a slope to build speed · a breakable wall at its bottom · a gap clearable only by charge-jump · a pressure plate requiring walk-mode precision · a crumble-floor with a weight threshold · a see-saw · a tall platform to slam from

Pass/fail test: with zero objectives and zero enemies, is charging down the slope into the wall grin-inducing within a day of tuning wind-up, steering, and impact numbers? If yes — the vision holds; everything else in this document builds on proven ground. If no after honest tuning effort — the problem is curve shapes or missing juice before it is the design; fix those first, then re-judge.

Secondary read: what the team actually plays with answers the B-vs-C lean. Everyone looping the slope-and-wall → B-primary. Everyone fiddling with the see-saw and plate → C-primary.

References & market position

Reference	What to take from it
Wario Land series (esp. II / 4)	The template: modal heavy hero, body as multitool, charm in bulk, walking deliberately unremarkable
Mario 64 / Banjo-Kazooie	Playground world structure, scattered objectives, re-entered worlds; Banjo proves puzzle-platforming works in them
Breath of the Wild / Tears of the Kingdom	Globally consistent rules, multiple-solution problems, legible goals, celebrate lateral thinking
Death Stranding	Deliberate movement stays fun when terrain constantly talks back
Donkey Kong Bananza (2025)	The anti-reference: joyful heavy smashing at AAA scale. The pure-action lane is owned

Differentiation: Bananza is unconstrained smashing; this game is **mass as a reasoning tool** — thresholds, structural logic, enemies as physics material, destruction you plan. A deliberate puzzle-

platformer with a heavy hero is a lane the action giants deliberately aren't in, and the smaller puzzle-platformer audience rewards exactly this kind of distinctiveness.